

COURSE FILE

PC732: Fundamentals of Design - II

Credit Structure: 3-0-4-5

Program: MDes (Communication Design)

Year: 1

Semester: 1

Duration: 18 Days (Full Day – Lecture + Studio)

Timing: 9 AM – 6 PM

Course Instructor: Anirban Dutta Gupta + Visiting Faculty

Couse Placement: Core course for MDes (CD) Semester 1. This course is composed of two parts – part A: Typography and Part B: Colour. Part A and Part B is taken consecutively. This is a foundational course in design.

Course Format: Module based. The course is taught as a combination of Lectures and Studio sessions. Lectures introduce concepts, which are then analysed and explored via studio sessions and assignments. Lecture and studio is integrated and in certain cases can overlap. Teaching is through hand-on learning and through learning-by-doing and via real-time demonstrations and guidance by faculty members.

Course Objective and Content:

This module deals with the advanced aspects of colour, composition, virtual 3D spaces, Typography as image, Illustration for information design, as means of explore, visualize and communicate complex ideas with high levels of data density.

This module would present an entry point to moving image and sound analysis, structure, methodology, concepts and experimentation for communicating specific ideas as well as to explore the possibilities and potential of each medium. Consideration of 'mediums' would focus on moving image scenarios that would include cinema, animation, multimedia and Sound Design and for 2D and virtual 3D environments.

Students will also engage with 'Design History' as a means of understanding visual language that is applied for range of visualization, essential for practice of sketching, photography, film and animation.

Typography is the art and technique of arranging type to make written language legible, readable, and visually appealing. It involves selecting typefaces (fonts), adjusting the spacing between letters (kerning), words (tracking), and lines (leading), and overall creating a visual style that complements the content and enhances the message being conveyed.

Key elements of typography include Typeface which is the design of the letters with each shape communicating a distinctive emotion, which evolves into a font which are the variations within the family for example, Helvetica Bold or Times New Roman Italic. Each type and its categories are steeped in history as it is usage and the message it communicates. For example, the gothic Germanic type is associated with the fascist ideology, hence its usage today may lead to negative interpretation with the values associated with fascism.

Beyond the selection of type, the second level is to manipulate the font to match to its usage. This includes understanding kerning - the space between two specific letters to improve legibility or visual balance, tracking - the space between all letters in a word or sentence, leading - the vertical space between lines of text, hierarchy - the arrangement of type elements to show their relative importance, often using different font sizes, weights, or styles to guide the reader, alignment – whether to position it left, right, center, or justified and contrast which is the differences in weight, size, or colour to create emphasis and improve readability.

Good typography can significantly affect how a message is perceived and can even evoke different emotional responses from the audience. It enhances readability and legibility ensuring that the text is easy to read. It helps in establishing a Visual Hierarchy by organizing information by signalling what's most important. This overlaps with some of the concepts that were discussed in FOD 1 – Composition module.

Typography also conveys tone and emotion, for example, Serif fonts (like Times New Roman) tend to be seen as formal, classic, and reliable. Sans-serif fonts (like Helvetica) are more modern, clean, and minimal. This leads into type as an element of brand design by creating a distinctive identity (Coca-Cola for example). It also helps in the aesthetic appeal with the right combination of font choices, spacing, and layout can make a design feel polished, cohesive, and visually striking, which grabs attention and makes an impact.

In the digital domain, typography is essential for a smooth user experience. If the type is hard to read, poorly spaced, or mismatched, users will likely get frustrated and leave. Consistent and accessible typography helps users navigate the content effortlessly.

Overall it guides the message by shaping how the message is understood and sets the mood for the audience. The wrong choice of typography could make a brand appear unprofessional, outdated, or inconsistent with its message. Typography, therefore, is a critical component of visual design because it goes beyond simply choosing a font. It's the art and technique of arranging type to make written language legible, readable, and appealing when displayed. This part of the module aims to sensitise the students to the variations of types and its uses.

The objective of part B i.e. Basics of colour is to sensitise the students to the 'idea' of colour and understand that there is no 'one' colour. Colour is tainted by light, culture, our perception, biology, emotion, chemistry and physics. Within this maze, we will try and identify and understand some of the broad rules that will allow us to make sense of colour. The objective is to teach and familiarize students with different methods of determining

successful colour schemes that will enhance their designs, as well as the emotional effectiveness that those choices can have in the marketplace. As part of this course, we will understand colour theory and derivations of colour. It will also acquaint you to shades, tints and tones as well as colour harmony and colour interaction. This overall understanding of colour will be an essential stepping stone to take conscious decisions on application of colour.

Colour is an integral component of design, playing a crucial role in shaping the visual and emotional experience of an audience. Colour is one of the most immediate and influential elements in design. The strategic use of colour can transform a design from a mere visual arrangement to a meaningful experience. The psychological effects of colour have long been studied in fields such as marketing, psychology, and design. Different colours evoke distinct emotional responses, which can influence perceptions and behaviour. For example, warm colours are commonly associated with energy, warmth, and urgency, while cool colours like often evoke calmness, trust, and professionalism. Understanding these emotional associations allows designers to select colours that align with the desired mood and tone of the design. It therefore, plays a fundamental role in establishing and reinforcing brand identity. The selection of a particular colour palette is often a deliberate decision aimed at differentiating a brand from its competitors while conveying specific values and messages. Consistent use of colour across various media platforms enhances brand recognition and fosters a sense of familiarity and trust with the audience.

Beyond its aesthetic and emotional impact, colour is also critical to the functionality and accessibility of a design. In digital design, for example, the contrast between text and background colours directly affects readability. A lack of sufficient contrast can make content difficult to read, leading to a poor user experience. Therefore, colour choices must be made with consideration of legibility and ease of navigation.

Colours also carry specific cultural meanings that vary across different regions and societies. The students are encouraged to link the use and significance of colour to the course in Culture and Communications. For instance, in Western cultures, white is often associated with purity and peace, whereas in some Eastern cultures, it symbolizes mourning and death. Designers must be aware of these cultural connotations to avoid miscommunication or unintended negative associations when designing for global audiences. Moreover, colour symbolism can be employed strategically to reinforce the intended message of a design.

Colour is fundamental to the creation of aesthetic cohesion and visual harmony within a design. A well-thought-out colour palette can unify disparate elements, creating a balanced and pleasing composition. The principles of colour theory, including complementary, analogous, and triadic colour schemes, guide designers in selecting harmonious combinations that are visually engaging and balanced. Colour adds another dimension to the principles of composition that was explored in FOD 1.

Knowledge and Skill targets:

Knowledge:

1. What is colour
2. History of Colour
3. Colour and emotion
4. Colour interaction
5. Colour and culture
6. Colour and Design
7. Typography and its component
8. History of typography
9. Type and emotion
10. Type and design

11. Type as display, type as body text, digital type
12. Type and scale
13. Integration – judgement, interaction and decisions

Skill:

1. Colour application and mixing
2. Hue, Saturation, tint, shade
3. Greyscale and RGB Wheel
4. RGB vs CMYK
5. Physical colour vs screen colour
6. Using colour for representation
7. Elements of type – size, leading, kerning, spacing etc
8. Type narrative

Assessment Method: Continuous assessment of application of concepts through the duration of the course, along with assessment of group and individual assignments given. Assessment will not only cover the assignments, but professionalism, precision, pride, care and discipline displayed by the students.

P1	P2	P3	P4	P5	P6	P7	P8	P9	P10	P11	P12
	X	X	X	X		X	X	X	X	X	X

Course Outcome: The course aims to equip the students with professional knowledge – creative, narrative and technical – on the fundamental building blocks of design approach – that of (Part A) colour, colour usage, colour psychology, (Part B) typography, type and its meaning, type and emotion, type and usage along with integrating aspects of FOD 1 and FOD 2 for a final segment where these concepts, skills, knowledge are applied in a final

project which can be designing a poster or any complex visual representation. This course prepares the students for professional application of these basic guidelines which will be applied in all design fields going ahead.

Growth Matrix:

Flow	Objectives
1	Exercise 1.1: Understanding shade & tint Objective: To understand and appreciate the how black and white behaves as well as tool usage – brush, paint, palette, fluidity, paper
2	Exercise 1.2: Understanding colour – primary, secondary, tertiary using a colour wheel Objective: To understand primary, secondary and tertiary colours
3	Exercise 1.3: Understanding colour interaction Objective: Understanding what colour works with what.
4	Exercise 1.4: Application of colour knowledge through deconstruction of a painting and changing the colour to change the emotion Objective: Understand colour and emotions
5	Exercise 1.5: Colour and abstraction – listen to a musical piece and draw it in colour. Objective: Applying colours based on feelings

6	Exercise 1.6: Colours in 3-Dimension Objective: How colours work in the 3-Dimensional space.
7	Exercise 2.1: Understanding typography Objective: To understand the elements of typography.
8	Exercise 2.2: Elements of type – deconstruct and reconstruct a type to understand the various elements that go into making a type like x-height etc. Objective: To appreciate the derivation of form and shape of the type and the stories behind them
9	Exercise 2.3: Compare a serif and a san-serif type to appreciate the difference between them Objective: What do each different types of type communicate
10	Exercise 2.4: Using type – leading, kerning, spacing etc. Objective: How to use these features in a composition
11	Exercise 2.5: Type in a composition Objective: How is type used to communicate
12	Exercise 2.1: Integration through spread, poster or infographic design Objective: Fundamentals of design I & II applied in this exercise.

Some things to keep in mind:

- Attendance is mandatory. You will have to be present during class hours.
- All assignments have to be completed.
- Use of any form of AI tools to generate concepts is strictly forbidden unless discussed in class and allowed for the specific assignment.

Reference:

- *The Elements of Typographic Style* by Robert Bringhurst
 - *Thinking with Type* by Ellen Lupton
 - *Stop Stealing Sheep & Find Out How Type Works* by Erik Spiekermann & E.M. Ginger
 - *The New Typography* by Jan Tschichold
 - *Grid Systems in Graphic Design* by Josef Müller-Brockmann
 - *Just My Type* by Simon Garfield
 - *Interaction of Color* by Josef Albers
 - *The Art of Color* by Johannes Itten
 - *The Designer's Dictionary of Color* by Sean Adams
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